

The previous chapter was dedicated to giving you just a handful of examples of why we think mankind was always headed towards advanced technology, and as a result, AI. This chapter will look at some of the people in more recent times who were instrumental in all the progress we've seen in the field of AI. You will also be able to read about some of their work and concepts in subsequent chapters. Of course there are thousands of contributors, each of whom have played a very special part in the development of AI, and detailing them all would be beyond the scope of this book, so we'll stick to our picks of the important few.

To start talking about AI in the modern sense, one has to start with Alan Turing. Turing carries the distinction of being known as the father of computer science and AI. During the World War II, Turing was known to be the brains behind Bombe – the electro-mechanical machine that was finally able to decrypt the German Enigma code that had foxed the allies for much of WWII. However, in the context of this book, it was Turing who first posed the question “Can machines think?” in a 1950 paper titled Computing Machinery and Intelligence. Although Turing is revered by us geeks, he was ostracised in his own time for his sexual orientation. Arrested for being a homosexual in 1952, he was given a choice between prison and chemical castration. He



Alan Turing: the man behind the test we use even today to discern whether an “intelligence” has been created